Besides, what I had primarily learnt during this war was the value of time and life. Evacuation of casualties from the front line would often become part of my sorties. I remember one such casualty evacuation quite distinctly.

We had just dropped some supplies and passengers from Srinagar to Kargil. On our way back, the captain received a radio call asking him to take a detour, since a soldier who had been severely injured had to be evacuated urgently. Upon receiving the coordinates for the helipad, we redirected our helicopter towards the given location. But by the time we reached, the soldier had succumbed to his injuries. A bullet had hit his head, we were told.

The officer-in-charge in that location asked the captain if we could carry the mortal remains of the soldier to Srinagar. He asked me if I would be comfortable with it, since the body would be strapped to the passenger seat, there being no space for a coffin inside the small cabin of our Cheetah helicopter. I told him that it was the least we could do for the martyred soldier. But the entire process of getting his mortal remains to the helicopter and then carefully placing the body on the passenger seat did shake me up.

I felt a sort of grief that is inexplicable. Seeing his head wrapped in a cloth and his uniform crimsoned with blood was something that made me wonder if this soldier had experienced a lot of pain. *What would have been his last thoughts? How would his parents react when they were told their son was no more? Was he married? Did he have children? What about all the plans he must have had for the future?* Such questions roiled inside my head until we landed at the Srinagar airbase. But such is the uncertainty of a soldier's life, I reminded myself. There is glory in fighting to save the integrity of one's nation and dying in the process. A death like this is earned by fortunate men and women. I saluted the martyr and vowed to myself that I would honour the supreme sacrifice of all martyrs of war by doing my duty undauntedly. This kept me going till the end of the war.

In the second week of July, a victorious mood could be felt everywhere. It was a decisive victory for the Indian troops, which had been successful in drawing out the infiltrators and recapturing vital peaks. But it had all come at the cost of loading tens of coffins every day. Nevertheless, their sacrifice